

TRAINER GUIDE · eCTM TIMELINE + RETURN-TO-WORK · BERTONE ET AL. 2026

Timing the layup. Planning the return.

What the trial says about how a horse on eCTM should be tracking at week 2, 4, 12, and 26.

What the trial delivered for the trainer

BACK TO PRIOR WORK · 26 WEEKS 79% single eCTM injection · vs. 21% on standard of care Four out of five horses returned to — or exceeded — their prior level of work six months after a single injection.	FIRST OBSERVABLE CHANGE 2 wk pain + swelling separate from standard of care By the two-week re-check, the treated horse should be moving and feeling different — not perfect yet, but noticeably better.	STRUCTURAL LAMENESS IMPROVES 4 wk lameness scores separate · widen through wk 12 The vet's lameness exam is the right decision point at four weeks. Waiting until six or eight weeks costs you a training block.
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A trial-aligned layup and return plan Coordinate all workload decisions with the treating veterinarian.

Week 2 First re-check	Expect visible change in pain and swelling. Not soundness — comfort. If nothing looks different at week 2, call the vet before deciding next steps.
Week 4 First real decision	Vet re-evaluates lameness. This is the trial window where treated horses separated from standard care. If the horse is trending, hold the current plan. If not, escalate the workup, not the workload.
Week 12 The primary endpoint	By 12 weeks, treated horses in the trial were consistently outperforming standard of care on pain, swelling, and lameness. Reasonable window for beginning tack-walking / long-line work if the vet clears it.
Week 26 Back to prior work	Six months is the trial's return-to-work endpoint. 79% of treated horses were back to — or above — prior performance. This is the milestone to plan the show / event calendar around, not week 8 or 12.

Plan the layup on the trial's clock: 2 · 4 · 12 · 26 weeks.

Equine Performance Labs

One injection. Four decision points. A 6-month return-to-work milestone the trial actually delivered.